



► Angelic assistance

These pages from the 13th-century *Sworn Book of Honorius* give details of angels that the book's rituals aim to summon.

The Notary Arts

The most famous magical handbook was the *Picatrix* (see pp.82–83)—a book on astral magic originally written in Arabic—but there were other influential titles. One such was the *Ars notoria* (“The Notary Arts”), a collective title for texts that reputedly offered their users a shortcut to academic excellence and wisdom: Christian angel magic. The *Ars notoria*

includes prosaic techniques for improving memory, as well as prayers to summon angels to give the user intellectual powers, such as mastery of languages. The earliest *Ars notoria* text dates from the 12th century, and it remained famous throughout and even beyond the medieval period.

The Sworn Book

Written later than the first *Ars Notoria* and probably influenced by it, *The Sworn Book of Honorius* is part of a group of “Solomonic” manuscripts—so called because their writers claim to have links to King Solomon—which contain prayers that call on the power of angels. Its opening pages state that it was produced after a council of magicians chose an author to record angelic knowledge. Made up of 93 chapters, the book covers a range of topics, from how to catch thieves and find treasure to how to summon “the evil spirits of the earth.” No one knows its true origin, or who the supposed author, Honorius of Thebes, was. His name has also been linked to the Theban alphabet (see p.145) used by Renaissance occultists and later by Wiccans—an example of the continuing practice of creating authenticity by attributing ideas to famous figures.

IN CONTEXT

The future of the grimoire

Books of magic, including the famous *De occulta philosophia libri tres* by German occult philosopher Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa, were among the first books to be printed after the invention of the printing press in the 15th century. Grimoires, as they are now called, have continued to be popular ever since, even though they were pushed out of the mainstream by the development of science and rationalism in the 18th century. In the 20th century new grimoires continued to appear, although many claim to be based on older originals. For example, the *Secret Grimoire of Turiel* (1927) is said to have come from a 16th-century transcript of a much earlier text.



This illustration from a demonology grimoire dates from 1775, but claims to be based on a 1057 original.

